

RSU / IRS 127

Introduction to Intercultural Communication

How do people create shared meaning across differences?

Intercultural Communication



A message can have more than one meaning

“Please send me your part of the assignment soon.”

What might the sender intend? What might the receiver hear?



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Start with your own experience

Think of a time when someone misunderstood your words, tone, silence, or message.

Tell a partner: What happened, and what helped?



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

By the end, you can...

Use the chapter ideas to communicate more thoughtfully.

1 Explain how communication, culture, identity, and context connect.

2 Recognize stereotypes and overgeneralizations.

3 Compare face-to-face and digital encounters.

4 Apply intercultural competence in PAL interactions.



Choose one goal that matters most to you. Explain why.

Meaning is created together

Communication is not only sending information. The receiver interprets it.

In pairs, finish: “Understanding becomes difficult when...”



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Words and signals work together

VERBAL

Spoken or written language: word choice, grammar, explanations.

NONVERBAL

Tone, facial expression, gesture, eye contact, posture, distance, silence.



Which signal would you trust if the words and tone disagreed? Why?

Interpret the whole situation

SCENARIO

A classmate says, “I am happy to help,” but uses a flat voice, avoids eye contact, and leaves quickly.

YOUR GROUP

Reader • interpreter •
alternative-explanation
finder



What are two possible meanings? What context would you need?

Context changes meaning

“That is interesting.”

Say it three ways: praise, surprise, and polite disagreement.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Check before you judge

Effective communicators treat first interpretations as possibilities.

1 Observe the words and nonverbal behavior.

2 Consider the relationship and setting.

3 Ask a respectful clarifying question.

4 Adjust the message when confusion appears.



Rewrite one quick judgment as a curious question.

What counts as culture?

List three visible and three less-visible cultural features.

Compare lists. Which features are easiest to misunderstand?



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Culture is visible and less visible

EASIER TO SEE

Food, clothing, music, festivals, greetings.

LESS VISIBLE

Politeness, authority, family duty, time, space, emotional expression.



How might one less-visible expectation affect group work?

Culture is not a fixed rule

Use cultural knowledge as a possible guide, not a prediction.

- 1 Learned through interaction and institutions.
- 2 Shared, but not identical for every member.
- 3 Dynamic and changed by contact and technology.
- 4 Diverse within every group.



Create one careful sentence that begins: “Some people may...”

Nationality is only one influence

What groups or communities have shaped how you communicate?

Choose three. Explain one communication habit connected to each.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Three useful lenses

INTRACULTURAL

Interaction among people who perceive an important shared cultural background.

CROSS-CULTURAL

Comparison of communication patterns across cultural groups.



Where does direct interaction across meaningful differences fit? Explain.

Classify the encounter

SCENARIO

A Thai engineering student and a Thai arts student disagree about how formal a group presentation should be.

YOUR GROUP

Classifier • evidence
finder • challenger



Is this intracultural, intercultural, or both? What difference matters?

Identity has many parts

Complete: “In different situations, people may see me as...”

Share only the identities you are comfortable discussing.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Multiple identities intersect

No single label explains a person.

- 1 Personal: interests, abilities, goals, experiences.
- 2 Social: relationships and group memberships.
- 3 Cultural, national, ethnic, linguistic, religious, gender, professional.
- 4 Different parts become important in different contexts.



Which identity is most visible in class? Which is less visible?

Communication can shape belonging

SCENARIO

A multilingual student's ideas are repeatedly ignored until another classmate repeats them more fluently.

YOUR GROUP

Observer • student
advocate • group
leader



What happened to belonging? What should the group do next?

Generalization or stereotype?

CAREFUL GENERALIZATION

A possible pattern that allows individual and situational variation.

STEREOTYPE

A simplified belief applied to members of a group without enough evidence.



Revise: “Westerners are direct” into a responsible statement.

Ask, do not assume

Choose one question that lets a person describe how they wish to be understood.

Practise asking it respectfully, then listen without correcting.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Intercultural communication is everywhere

Where do differences become meaningful?

- 1 University classrooms and group projects.
- 2 Workplaces, clients, and online teams.
- 3 Travel, tourism, and migration.
- 4 Friendships, families, and digital communities.



Each group chooses one setting and predicts one opportunity and one challenge.

Participation can look different

SCENARIO

**One student speaks often to show interest.
Another listens quietly to show attention and respect.**

YOUR GROUP

Student A • Student B
• inclusive facilitator



How can the group include both without labeling either student?

Feedback depends on expectations

SCENARIO

A manager gives direct criticism during a meeting. An employee expected private and indirect feedback.

YOUR GROUP

Manager • employee •
mediator



How could each person adapt while keeping the feedback clear?

Small actions affect belonging

Which everyday action can help a newcomer feel included at university?

Give a specific example, not a general value.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Diversity exists within Thailand

What differences can exist among people who all identify as Thai?

Build a group list without describing any group as uniform.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

One region, many communities

ASEAN is culturally, linguistically, ethnically, and religiously diverse.

- 1 Different national and regional histories.
- 2 Many languages and varieties of English.
- 3 Different religious and social traditions.
- 4 Mobility through study, tourism, migration, and work.



What communication skill matters across all four areas? Defend your choice.

English is a shared resource

SCENARIO

An ASEAN project team uses English. Members have different accents, vocabulary, and levels of fluency.

YOUR GROUP

Chair • two members •
communication
observer



Design three rules that create understanding without demanding one “perfect” accent.

Multilingual strategies are strengths

**Repetition • examples • gestures • translation •
more than one language**

Which strategy helps you most? Demonstrate it with a partner.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Different channels provide different clues

FACE-TO-FACE

Immediate feedback, tone, gesture, expression, posture, distance.

DIGITAL

Communication across distance and time, but often with fewer contextual signals.



When would changing the channel prevent a misunderstanding?

A short message feels rude

SCENARIO

A classmate replies only, “Fine.” You cannot see their face or hear their tone.

YOUR GROUP

Receiver • sender •
neutral adviser



List three interpretations. Write one clarification that avoids accusation.

Formality is not universal

SCENARIO

A student emails a lecturer: “Hey, send me the file.” The student believes the message is friendly and efficient.

YOUR GROUP

Student • lecturer •
reviser



What is the likely effect? Rewrite the message for this relationship.

Pause before you post

Digital messages can travel beyond the intended audience.

- 1 Check accuracy and audience.
- 2 Protect private information and seek permission.
- 3 Avoid harmful stereotypes and personal attacks.
- 4 Allow time and access for different participants.



Choose one principle and explain what it looks like in a class group chat.

Intention and effect both matter

SCENARIO

A joke was intended to be friendly, but a classmate felt embarrassed and excluded.

YOUR GROUP

Speaker • classmate •
repair coach



Create a response that explains intention, recognizes effect, and repairs trust.

Competence is not perfection

It means being willing to learn, adapt, reflect, and communicate respectfully.

Name one mistake that could become a useful learning experience.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Four parts work together

Competence develops through practice and reflection.

- 1 Knowledge of culture, identity, context, and self.
- 2 Attitudes: curiosity, openness, empathy, respect.
- 3 Skills: listening, observing, clarifying, negotiating meaning.
- 4 Critical awareness of assumptions, power, and stereotypes.



Which part is strongest for you? Which needs practice?

Clarify and negotiate meaning

**Partner A explains an unfamiliar local practice.
Partner B asks questions and paraphrases.**

Switch roles after one minute. Avoid pretending to understand.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question

Equal participation may need different support

SCENARIO

A second-language speaker needs more time to answer, while faster speakers repeatedly fill every silence.

YOUR GROUP

Facilitator • fast speaker • reflective observer



What boundary or routine would make participation more equitable?

The PAL center is an intercultural space

SCENARIO

A Team Leader uses slang and speaks quickly. Several mentees smile politely but contribute very little.

YOUR GROUP

Team Leader • mentee
• observer



Diagnose the problem. Demonstrate a more inclusive approach.

Experience becomes learning through reflection

After an intercultural encounter, pause and examine it.

1 What happened, without judgment?

2 What did I feel and assume?

3 How might others have understood it?

4 What will I change next time?



Write one personal intercultural goal for this course.

Your next interaction is the real assessment

Be curious. Check meaning. Protect dignity. Reflect and adjust.

Tell a partner one action you will practise this week.



Listen • explain • ask one follow-up question